

Little Commanders

2–6 players · about 45 minutes · ages 8+

Rulebook draft v0.1 (plain text, no art yet)

1 The Idea

Six kids, six toy armies. Each commander leads cute little **Bots** and a few huge **Mechs** across a floor of hexagon tiles. Dig up iron and crystal, build factories, grab land, and complete **Missions**. The first commander to reach **5 Victory Points** wins.

2 Components

- Land tiles: 37 (centre + 3 rings) and 6 Home tiles. Sea tiles: 12 Port tiles.
- 6 Player boards (one per faction) and 1 Market board.
- Per player: 20 Bots, 6 Mechs, 5 Extractors, 5 Factories, 5 Guard Towers, 1 Dock.
- Tokens: Iron, Crystal, Credit coins (1, 5, 10), price markers, VP markers.
- 40 Mission cards (20 of Level 1, 20 of Level 2).

3 Setup

1. **Board.** 2–3 players use 19 land tiles (centre and 2 rings). 4–6 players use 37 land tiles (centre and 3 rings). Within each ring the tiles are shuffled and placed at random. Roads must line up only where *both* touching tiles show one.
2. **Ports.** Place 2 Port tiles per player just outside the land. Each Port joins by road to the 2 land tiles beside it.
3. **Homes.** Spread the Home tiles evenly around the outer ring. Each player takes one, with a Dock and a Guard Tower on it, **2 Iron** and **3 Bots**. Build your first Extractor with that Iron.
4. **Market.** Set the four price markers (Iron, Bots, Crystal, Mechs) at random in their starting band: Iron 4–7, Bots 4–7, Crystal 8–14, Mechs 8–14.
5. **Missions.** Shuffle 10 random Level 1 cards and 10 random Level 2 cards. Level 1 cards go on top. Reveal 5.
6. The first player starts with 10 Credits. Everyone else receives their 10 Credits at the start of their first turn, like all income.

4 Your Turn

There are no rounds. When your turn starts, you receive **+10 Credits** and all your Extractors refresh. Then do any of the actions below, in any order and as often as you can pay for. End your turn when done; your attacks resolve then.

4.1 Control

You **control** a tile while at least one of your pieces is on it. Every building and token on a tile belongs to whoever controls the tile. Bots cannot be assigned to buildings. They only hold tiles and attack.

4.2 Build

Pay iron that is standing on the tile, and use a free building area there:

Building	What it does	Cost
Extractor	Once per turn, pay 1 Credit to take 1 token of the tile's resource	1 Iron
Factory	1 Iron $\rightarrow$ 2 Bots, or 1 Iron + 1 Crystal $\rightarrow$ 1 Mech	2 Iron
Guard Tower	Makes the tile harder to push and kill (see Combat)	2 Iron

An Extractor needs a tile with a resource. A tile has 0, 1 or 2 building areas. You can sell a building: it returns to your board and you get its cost minus 1 Iron back onto the tile.

4.3 Make Pieces

At a Factory, spend its inputs from the same tile. New Bots and Mechs appear on that tile. They come from your player board's supply (20 Bots, 6 Mechs).

4.4 Move

Each piece pays the **triangular cost** of its *total* steps this turn: 1 step costs 1, 2 steps cost 3, 3 steps cost 6, 4 steps cost 10. Credits already paid for that piece this turn count toward the new total, so a piece that has moved can keep going and only pays the difference. Pieces follow open roads and cannot pass through enemy pieces.

4.5 Trade

- Trade from a tile you control that has a Dock or a Port.
- Your home Dock trades **Iron** and **Bots** at the current market price.
- A Port is a separate tile outside the land. Each Port buys one good for 2 Credits less, or pays 3 Credits more when you sell it.
- You choose a quantity. Every item trades at the current price, then the price moves one step per item traded (up when bought, down when sold). A step is 1 Credit for Iron and Bots, 2 Credits for Crystal and Mechs. Prices only move when somebody trades.
- Price ranges: Iron 1–10, Bots 1–10, Crystal 2–20, Mechs 2–20.

4.6 Missions

Pay **5 Credits** to buy a face-up Mission, plus 1 more for every Mission you have already bought. You may buy one per turn. If you meet its condition *at that moment* you score its VP (1 for Level 1, 2 for Level 2). If you do not, the Credits are lost. A completed card is replaced from the deck.

4.7 Undo

Undo and Undo all (digital version) take back your actions in the current turn. They disappear when the turn ends.

5 Combat

Move pieces onto an enemy tile to attack it. Attackers walk in; the attack is decided when you end your turn.

- A Bot has power **1**. A Mech has power **4**.
- Add up the attackers' power and the defenders' power.
- **Push:** the attackers' total is at least **2**× the defenders'. The defenders must retreat. The defending player chooses the tile each pushed piece retreats to.
- **Kill:** the attackers' total is at least **3**× the defenders'. The defenders are removed.
- Each Guard Tower on the tile adds 1 to both multipliers (push $2 \rightarrow 3 \rightarrow \dots$, kill $3 \rightarrow 4 \rightarrow \dots$).
- If defenders remain, it is an **attack failure**: the attackers return to where they came from.

6 Winning

The first player to reach **5 Victory Points** wins immediately. Victory Points come only from Missions.

7 Factions

Six factions, each with its own colour and silhouette (so the game works without colour vision).

Colour	Mech	Bots
Red	Dragon	Rocket-pods
Blue	Crab	Submarines
Green	Beetle	Sprouts and watering cans
Yellow	Tower	Lightbulbs
Purple	Owl	Bat-wing ghosts
Orange	Scrap giant	Tin cans and cardboard

Faction powers are being designed. See `ART_PLAN.md`.

8 Quick Reference

Income	+10 Credits at the start of your turn
Extractor	1 Credit, once per turn, 1 token
Build costs	Extractor 1, Factory 2, Guard Tower 2 Iron
Factory	1 Iron → 2 Bots; 1 Iron + 1 Crystal → 1 Mech
Move cost (per piece)	1, 3, 6, 10 for 1, 2, 3, 4 steps
Power	Bot 1, Mech 4
Push / Kill	2× / 3× defenders' power (+1 each per Guard Tower)
Mission cost	5 Credits, +1 per Mission bought, one per turn
Win	5 VP
